S T A R T H E R E

Complete Beginner's Guide to Japanese

日本語をはじめよう — Let's start Japanese

This guide is for complete beginners — no Japanese knowledge required.

What's inside:

PART 1 — What is Japanese? The three scripts explained
PART 2 — Hiragana: all 46 base characters + voiced sounds + WRITING PRACTICE
PART 3 — Katakana: all 46 base characters + voiced sounds + WRITING PRACTICE
PART 4 — The best method to learn Japanese (honest, practical advice)
PART 5 — Your first week study plan
PART 6 — Recommended free resources

By the end of this guide you will be able to read AND write every hiragana and katakana character — the essential first step in learning Japanese.

PART 1

What is Japanese?

Japanese uses three different scripts — all at the same time

This is probably the biggest shock for English speakers. Japanese doesn't use an alphabet. Instead, it uses THREE different writing systems that appear mixed together in the same sentence. Don't panic — each one has a clear purpose, and you'll be able to read and write two of them completely within a few weeks.

ひらがな ~1–2 weeks	**HIRAGANA** 46 characters. Soft, rounded shapes. Used for native Japanese words, verb endings, and grammar particles. This is the FIRST thing you learn.
カタカナ ~1–2 weeks	**KATAKANA** 46 characters. Angular, sharp shapes. Used almost exclusively for foreign loanwords: コーヒー = koohii = coffee. Learn this second.
漢字 ~Ongoing	**KANJI** Thousands of characters borrowed from Chinese. JLPT N5 requires ~100. Learn these gradually over months — the N5 Integrated Workbook covers all of them.

💡 What does a real Japanese sentence look like?

Here is a real Japanese sentence using all three scripts:

私はコーヒーが好きです。
Watashi wa koohii ga suki desu.
I like coffee.

Breaking it down:
私 = kanji (watashi = I)
は = hiragana (wa = topic particle)
コーヒー = katakana (koohii = coffee — loanword from English)
が = hiragana (ga = subject particle)
好き = kanji + hiragana (suki = like)
です。= hiragana (desu = polite ending)

PART 2

Hiragana ひらがな

What is Hiragana?

Hiragana is a syllabic alphabet — each character represents a sound (a syllable), not a single consonant like English letters. There are 46 base characters. Once you know them all, you can sound out any Japanese word written in hiragana.

🎯 How to read this chart

Each character represents a consonant + vowel sound.
The top row (—) are the pure vowels: a i u e o
The K row makes: ka ki ku ke ko
The S row: sa shi su se so (note: si → shi)
The T row: ta chi tsu te to (note: ti → chi, tu → tsu)
The H row: ha hi fu he ho (note: hu → fu)
Y and W rows have gaps — those sounds don't exist in Japanese.
ん (n) is the only standalone consonant — it never starts a word.

The 46 Base Hiragana Characters

	a	i	u	e	o
—	あ a	い i	う u	え e	お o
K	か ka	き ki	く ku	け ke	こ ko
S	さ sa	し shi	す su	せ se	そ so
T	た ta	ち chi	つ tsu	て te	と to
N	な na	に ni	ぬ nu	ね ne	の no
H	は ha	ひ hi	ふ fu	へ he	ほ ho
M	ま ma	み mi	む mu	め me	も mo
Y	や ya		ゆ yu		よ yo
R	ら	り	る	れ	ろ

	ra	ri	ru	re	ro
W	わ wa				を wo
N	ん n				

Voiced Sounds

Adding ゛ (top right) voices the consonant. Adding ゜ (small circle) to the H row creates P sounds.

	a	i	u	e	o
G	が ga	ぎ gi	ぐ gu	げ ge	ご go
Z	ざ za	じ ji	ず zu	ぜ ze	ぞ zo
D	だ da	ぢ ji	づ zu	で de	ど do
B	ば ba	び bi	ぶ bu	べ be	ぼ bo
P	ぱ pa	ぴ pi	ぷ pu	ぺ pe	ぽ po

✏️ How to memorise hiragana

The most proven method: MNEMONICS — each character looks like something.

- あ (a) = someone sitting cross-legged. き (ki) = a key. Use Dr. Moku's app.
- Write each character 5× saying the sound aloud. Cover and recall next day.
- Target: 5 new characters per day = all 46 in under 10 days.

PART 2 (Practice)

Hiragana Writing Practice ひらがな れんしゅう

For each character: trace the light guide in box 1, then write from memory in boxes 2–9.
Say the sound aloud every time. Come back and repeat the whole section after 2 days.

Base Hiragana — Vowels & K–N rows

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

あ *a*

あ								

い *i*

い								

う *u*

う								

え *e*

え								

お *o*

お

か *ka*

か

き *ki*

き

く *ku*

く

け *ke*

け

こ *ko*

こ								

さ *sa*

さ								

し *shi*

し								

す *su*

す								

せ *se*

せ								

そ *so*

そ								

た *ta*

た								

ち *chi*

ち								

つ *tsu*

つ								

て *te*

て								

と *to*

と								

な *na*

な								

に *ni*

に								

ぬ *nu*

ぬ								

ね *ne*

ね								

の *no*

の								

Base Hiragana — H–N rows + W row + ん

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

は *ha*

は								

ひ *hi*

ひ								

ふ *fu*

ふ								

へ *he*

へ								

ほ *ho*

ほ								

ま *ma*

ま								

み *mi*

み								

む *mu*

む								

め *me*

め								

も *mo*

も								

や *ya*

や								

ゆ *yu*

ゆ								

よ *yo*

よ								

ら *ra*

ら								

り *ri*

り								

る *ru*

る								

れ *re*

れ

ろ *ro*

ろ

わ *wa*

わ

を *wo*

を

ん *n*

ん

Voiced Hiragana (゛ ゜)

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

が *ga*

が								

ぎ *gi*

ぎ								

ぐ *gu*

ぐ								

げ *ge*

げ								

ご *go*

ご								

ざ *za*

ざ								

じ *ji*

じ								

ず *zu*

ず								

ぜ *ze*

ぜ								

ぞ *zo*

ぞ								

だ *da*

だ								

ぢ *ji*

ぢ								

づ *zu*

づ								

で *de*

で								

ど *do*

ど								

ば *ba*

ば								

び *bi*

び

ぶ *bu*

ぶ

べ *be*

べ

ぼ *bo*

ぼ

ぱ *pa*

ぱ

ぴ *pi*

ぴ								

ぷ *pu*

ぷ								

ぺ *pe*

ぺ								

ぽ *po*

ぽ								

PART 3

Katakana カタカナ

What is Katakana?

Katakana represents the exact same sounds as hiragana but with angular, sharp-looking characters. It is used almost exclusively for foreign loanwords, foreign names, and scientific terms.

💡 The secret advantage of katakana

Because katakana is mainly used for English loanwords, you already know hundreds of Japanese words!

テレビ (terebi) = TV　　コーヒー (koohii) = coffee
レストラン (resutoran) = restaurant　　スマホ (sumaho) = smartphone
アイスクリーム (aisukuriimu) = ice cream

The long vowel mark ー stretches the previous vowel: コー = kooo, コーヒー = koohii.

The 46 Base Katakana Characters

	a	i	u	e	o
—	ア a	イ i	ウ u	エ e	オ o
K	カ ka	キ ki	ク ku	ケ ke	コ ko
S	サ sa	シ shi	ス su	セ se	ソ so
T	タ ta	チ chi	ツ tsu	テ te	ト to
N	ナ na	ニ ni	ヌ nu	ネ ne	ノ no
H	ハ ha	ヒ hi	フ fu	ヘ he	ホ ho
M	マ ma	ミ mi	ム mu	メ me	モ mo
Y	ヤ ya		ユ yu		ヨ yo
R	ラ ra	リ ri	ル ru	レ re	ロ ro

W	ワ wa				ヲ wo
N	ン n				

Voiced Katakana

	a	i	u	e	o
G	ガ ga	ギ gi	グ gu	ゲ ge	ゴ go
Z	ザ za	ジ ji	ズ zu	ゼ ze	ゾ zo
D	ダ da	ヂ ji	ヅ zu	デ de	ド do
B	バ ba	ビ bi	ブ bu	ベ be	ボ bo
P	パ pa	ピ pi	プ pu	ペ pe	ポ po

✏️ **Most confusing katakana pairs**

ソ (so) vs ン (n) | ツ (tsu) vs シ (shi) | ワ (wa) vs ウ (u)

Write each one 10 times in a row while saying the sound aloud to distinguish them.

PART 3 (Practice)

Katakana Writing Practice カタカナ れんしゅう

Trace the guide character in box 1. Write from memory in boxes 2–9.
Tip: after completing each row, try writing a loanword using those characters.

Base Katakana — Vowels & K–N rows

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

ア *a*

ア								

イ *i*

イ								

ウ *u*

ウ								

エ *e*

エ								

オ *o*

オ

カ *ka*

カ

キ *ki*

キ

ク *ku*

ク

ケ *ke*

ケ

コ *ko*

コ								

サ *sa*

サ								

シ *shi*

シ								

ス *su*

ス								

セ *se*

セ								

ソ *so*

ソ								

タ *ta*

タ								

チ *chi*

チ								

ツ *tsu*

ツ								

テ *te*

テ								

ト *to*

ト								

ナ *na*

ナ

二 *ni*

二

ヌ *nu*

ヌ

ネ *ne*

ネ

ノ *no*

ノ

Base Katakana — H–N rows + W row + ン

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

ハ *ha*

ハ								

ヒ *hi*

ヒ								

フ *fu*

フ								

ヘ *he*

ヘ								

ホ *ho*

ホ								

マ *ma*

マ								

ミ *mi*

ミ								

ム *mu*

ム								

メ *me*

メ								

モ *mo*

モ								

ヤ *ya*

ヤ								

ユ *yu*

ユ								

ヨ *yo*

ヨ								

ラ *ra*

ラ								

リ *ri*

リ								

ル *ru*

ル								

レ *re*

レ								

ロ *ro*

ロ								

ワ *wa*

ワ								

ヲ *wo*

ヲ								

ン *n*

ン								

Voiced Katakana (゛ ゜)

Trace the guide character in the first box (light blue). Fill the remaining 8 boxes from memory.
Say the sound aloud every time you write. Focus on correct stroke order.

ガ *ga*

ガ								

ギ *gi*

ギ								

グ *gu*

グ								

ゲ *ge*

ゲ								

ゴ *go*

ゴ								

ザ *za*

ザ								

ジ *ji*

ジ								

ズ *zu*

ズ								

ゼ *ze*

ゼ								

ゾ *zo*

ゾ								

ダ *da*

ダ								

ヂ *ji*

ヂ								

ヅ *zu*

ヅ								

デ *de*

デ								

ド *do*

ド								

バ *ba*

バ								

ビ *bi*

ビ

ブ *bu*

ブ

ベ *be*

ベ

ボ *bo*

ボ

パ *pa*

パ

ピ *pi*

ピ								

プ *pu*

プ								

ペ *pe*

ペ								

ポ *po*

ポ								

PART 4

The Best Method to Learn Japanese

Honest advice — what actually works

There is no shortage of apps and courses that promise to make Japanese 'easy'. Most are overstated. Here is what the evidence and thousands of successful learners actually shows.

⚠️ **The truth about learning Japanese**

Japanese is genuinely one of the hardest languages for English speakers.
The US Foreign Service Institute rates it ~2,200 hours to professional proficiency.

That said — thousands of self-taught learners reach conversational fluency in 1–2 years with the right method and consistent daily study.

The difference between success and failure is almost always CONSISTENCY, not talent.
30 minutes every day beats 4 hours once a week.

1 Master Hiragana and Katakana first — completely

Do not move on until you can read both scripts without hesitation.
This is non-negotiable. Use this guide's writing practice sections until you have them.
Test yourself: open any Japanese website and try to sound out the kana.

2 Start a structured textbook as soon as kana is solid

Genki I is the gold standard — used by universities worldwide.
Free alternative: Japanese From Zero on YouTube (very beginner-friendly).
Go through it slowly. Do every exercise. Don't skip ahead.

3 Add Anki flashcards for vocabulary and kanji from day one

Anki is a free spaced-repetition app — the most efficient memorisation method.
Use the Core 2000 or Core 6000 Anki deck. Do 10–20 new cards per day.
Review every single day. This is not optional.

4 Consume real Japanese content as early as possible

NHK Web Easy (simplified news with furigana) from month 2 onwards.
Anime with Japanese subtitles, children's shows, simple manga.
You won't understand much at first — that's fine. The exposure matters.

5 Speak and write from the very beginning — don't wait

Use italki, HelloTalk, or Tandem to find conversation partners.
Write a journal in Japanese — even one sentence per day. Get corrections on HiNative.
Being embarrassed is a sign you're learning. Embrace it.

6 Be patient and consistent — results come slowly, then suddenly

Month 1–2: kana, basic vocab, basic grammar. It feels impossible.
Month 3–6: sentences start making sense. You recognise words in the wild.
Month 6–12: simple conversations become possible. Keep going.

PART 5

Your First Week Study Plan

30–40 minutes per day. This is achievable and will set you up for everything that follows.

Day	Goal	What to study
Day 1	Vowels + K row	あいうえお・かきくけこ — write each 5 times, say the sound aloud
Day 2	Review + S and T rows	さしすせそ・たちつてと — focus on the irregular sounds: shi, chi, tsu
Day 3	Review + N, H, M rows	なにぬねの・はひふへほ・まみむめも — note: hu → fu
Day 4	Review + Y, R, W, ん + dakuten	やゆよ・らりるれろ・わをん + voiced rows
Day 5	Full hiragana test	Cover the chart. Write all 46 from memory. Check every mistake.
Day 6	Start katakana — vowels + K, S, T rows	アイウエオ・カキクケコ・サシスセソ・タチツテト
Day 7	Review + write 3 loanwords	コーヒー・テレビ・スマホ — practice real words with what you know

✅ After your first week

You should be able to read all hiragana and be started on katakana.
From week 2: begin Genki I and add Anki with Core 2000 vocabulary.
Aim to keep this up for 100 days. At that point you'll be hooked.

PART 6

Recommended Resources

Learn Kana

Resource	What it is	Where to find it
Dr. Moku *App (iOS/Android)*	Mnemonic-based hiragana/katakana with animations. The fastest method.	*drmoku.com*
Tofugu Hiragana Guide *Free website*	In-depth guide with mnemonics, stroke order, and audio.	*tofugu.com/japanese/learn-hiragana*
Kana Quiz *Free website*	Timed kana recognition drills. Use after you've learned them.	*kana.pro*

Structured Learning

Resource	What it is	Where to find it
Genki I & II *Textbook*	Gold standard university textbook. Comprehensive and excellent.	*genki-jclub.co.jp*
Japanese From Zero *Free YouTube + book*	George Trombley's series. Free on YouTube, very clear.	*youtube.com/japanesefromzero*
Bunpro *Website/App*	Grammar SRS like Anki but for grammar patterns. Free tier available.	*bunpro.jp*

Vocabulary & Kanji

Resource	What it is	Where to find it
Anki *Free app*	Spaced repetition flashcards. Use Core 2000/6000 deck.	*apps.ankiweb.net*
WaniKani *Website*	Structured kanji learning with mnemonics + SRS. First 3 levels free.	*wanikani.com*
Jisho *Free website*	Best Japanese dictionary. Includes stroke order and JLPT level.	*jisho.org*

Immersion & Practice

Resource	What it is	Where to find it
NHK Web Easy *Free website*	Real news in simple Japanese with furigana. Perfect for beginners.	*www3.nhk.or.jp/news/easy*
italki	Find Japanese tutors or language exchange	*italki.com*

Resource	What it is	Where to find it
Website	partners.	
HelloTalk *App*	Chat with native Japanese speakers who want to learn English.	*hellotalk.com*

頑張ってください!

Ganbatte kudasai! — Do your best!

Remember:

- Hiragana first. Then katakana. Then everything else.
- 30 minutes every day beats 4 hours once a week.
- Your next step after this guide: the N5 Integrated Learning Workbook in this library.
- Japanese is hard, but millions of people have learned it. You can too.